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Rethinking Educational Policies and Programs for Syrian Refugee Children in the MENA Region

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Introduction

In March 2011, the Syrian crisis began after brutal government attacks on public demonstrations to support teenagers who used graffiti to protest the government in the southern town of Daraa. After uncountable abuses of power, the conflict became a civil war that has been ongoing for over 13 years. Considered the world's largest refugee crisis by specialists, more than 14 million Syrians have been forcibly displaced since 2011 (UNHCR, 2023). This represents the largest population displacement, relative to size, since World War II (Watkins & Zyck, 2014). The Middle East and North Africa (MENA) region, particularly Syria, Jordan, and Lebanon, have absorbed most of this refugee flow (UNHCR, 2023).

While looking for safety and, potentially a new life, refugees face additional challenges in host countries. In February of 2023, 54,000 thousand people had their lives taken during two powerful earthquakes in southeastern Turkey and northern Syria, causing infrastructural damages and displacement of over 150,000 families. As a result, those already in urgent need are now calling for even greater humanitarian assistance and protection (UNHCR, 2023).

The situation becomes even more concerning when considering that nearly half of the 5.6 million Syrian refugees in the MENA region are minors (UNICEF, 2023). Despite the efforts of the United Nations Higher Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) and local agencies in host countries to offer them appropriate education through facilities and social initiatives, the increasing lack of funding has led them to face a lack of essential resources and access to this fundamental human right. This raises a critical question: to what extent can the UN, host countries, and local agencies provide adequate educational services under these challenging conditions?

Through an analysis of literature primarily focused on Jordan, Turkey, and Lebanon, this paper aims to understand some of the barriers to education faced by Syrian refugee children and explore how the large influx of this population has tested the capacity of the UN and local agencies to provide adequate educational services, as well as discuss new perspectives for budget allocation to strengthen educational services for Syrian child refugees.

Education of Syrian Refugee Children

Education is a source of development, human formation, and peace (UNHCR, 2022). Indeed, this human right plays a crucial role in forming children to become responsible citizens (Skovdal & Campbell, 2015) by increasing their social skills, and, consequently, resilience, a main tool for navigating challenges faced by vulnerable populations (Kuru et al., 2023). Particularly for refugees, schools are also important for identifying children who may be abused or subjected to early marriages, gender-based or sexual violence (SGBV) and to put them in contact with the right services (UNHCR, 2014). Furthermore, it also acts as a stabilizer and source of hope (Mrayan & Saleh, 2020) as it fosters a sense of protection, security, and belonging (Maadad & Matthews, 2018), avoiding participation in illicit activities (UNHCR, 2014), such as child labor, and service in radical groups, including the Islamic State (ISIS) (Watkins & Zyck, 2014).

Despite this importance, research shows that in recent years, on average, almost half of Syrian refugee children are not receiving formal education in host countries (UNHCR, 2022). This results in school enrollment rates lower than those in sub-Saharan African states and rising numbers as, each year, 100,000 Syrian children of school age annually find themselves without any educational opportunities (Watkins & Zyck, 2014), and 1.6 million run the danger of dropping out of school (UNHCR, 2023), with statistics being even worse for the female population (UNHCR, 2022).

However, this reality has not always been like this. Before the Civil War, education was one of the main priorities in the Syrian Government's agenda, which resulted in one of the Middle East's highest literacy rates (UNHCR, 2023), comparable to countries such as Malaysia and Thailand. Besides the destruction caused in thousands of schools (Watkins & Zyck, 2014), and the psychological effects caused by war, research suggests that other factors may have contributed to the current reality.

Challenges

Aiming to provide Syrian refugee children with better educational opportunities, governments of host countries have developed initiatives to integrate this population into their school system. However, this access does not always mean inclusion. Educational structures in host countries still lack well-trained teachers, infrastructure, proper learning and teaching materials, access to examination and valid certification, and psychological support aiming to support those students during their transition to a new

reality (UNHCR, 2022). Furthermore, many of those children face additional challenges that may prevent them from accessing schools and other facilities.

Child Marriage

Acting as a source of economic and social independence (Hattar-Pollara, 2019), education empowers refugee girls and changes their lives (Kuru et al., 2023). Despite this importance, previous research showed that young refugee girls in host countries can lose on average three years of regular schooling, and report being less valued, loved, and supported than their brothers (Hattar-Pollara, 2019). While investigating the causes for this discrepancy between boys and girls, some statistics stand out: in 2022, 20% of Syrian girls aged 15 to 19 were married, and 68% were absent from school any day throughout the 2021-2022 academic year. In the MENA region, Beirut exhibited the greatest incidence of child early marriage, standing at 36% (UNHCR, 2022).

Child Labor

In 2022, 17% of Syrian refugees aged 5 to 17 were employed, with boys being three times more likely to work than girls. (UNHCR, 2022). It becomes even more concerning while considering a rising trend, with Lebanon experiencing a doubling of its rates within a year. In many cases, those children are exposed to hazardous conditions, such as extreme temperatures, toxic gas, loud noise, and others that may cause injuries to health or safety (UNHCR, 2023).

The need to provide family support while facing financial constraints (Hattar-Pollara, 2019) and the lack of a male figure (Mrayan & Saleh, 2020) can be regarded as the primary causes of this disturbing scenario. This is reinforced by a collective idea held by many parents that the education received by their children would not be valid in Syria once they return, making their time working more valuable (Mrayan & Saleh, 2020). As a result, many children are exposed to some of the worst and most exploitative forms of labor, including running family stores, working in sales, food services, and manufacturing for over 12 hours a day (Watkins & Zyck, 2014).

Trauma and Psychological Disorders

Research has indicated that refugees fleeing war-torn areas have a higher predisposition to post-traumatic stress disorder compared to their levels of exposure among combat veterans when they return to their native countries (Hustache et al., 2009). For refugee children, especially the older ones, this is often observed in the lack of interest in the educational process, and an increased likelihood to show behavioral and emotional difficulties such as bullying, physical aggression, including hitting or pushing others, use of bad language, carelessness, withdrawal from family links (Mrayan & Saleh, 2020), and, consequently, less resilience that puts them at a higher risk of leaving school when faced with linguistic challenges or subjected to mistreatment and discrimination (Maadad & Matthews, 2018).

Additional Challenges

In overcrowded communities, many Syrian refugee households, averaging five people, live in unstable, non-residential shelters prone to collapse, putting them at greater risk from hazards such as fires and extreme weather (UNHCR, 2022). While living in these conditions, over 14% of refugees in Lebanon were classified as having a poor consumption score, and 6% of households still lack access to drinkable water, which pushes education to the background. Additionally, refugee camps and residential areas are often located in far, peripheral zones. Geographically, isolation bears a long journey from and to school, which is dangerous, especially without proper clothing that should cover them from the unpredicted harshness of the weather. Poor local health facilities make it even harder for ill or injured children to recover, taking them away from school for longer periods, and further cutting his or her learning process (Mrayan & Saleh, 2020).

Discrepancies in the host country's educational system may also present a significant hardship. This is because, while having to adjust to a new curriculum, which only teaches, for instance social sciences from a local and biased perspective (Maadad & Matthews, 2018), many refugee children may suffer from the lost fundamental abilities in math, reading, writing, and motivation to learn (Mrayan & Saleh, 2020), and struggle to obtain accreditation or acknowledgment for the education they obtained at home in Syria when they move to a new nation (Watkins & Zyck, 2014). Nonetheless, they also have to deal with teachers who do not show empathy (Hattar-Pollara, 2019) due to lack of proper training (Skovdal & Campbell, 2015)

and may not speak the same language as them. In countries such as Lebanon, basic subjects are frequently taught in French or English, while their parents, who could support them at home, only speak Arabic (Maadad & Matthews, 2018). This adaptation is even harder for gifted children who are mostly ignored and do not have access to specialized educational initiatives (Alodat & Almomani, 2019).

Host Countries

After 13 years of war, Syria continues to have the largest refugee flow globally. Since 2011, more than 14 million Syrians have been forced to flee their homes to find refuge. The neighboring countries of Turkey, Lebanon, Jordan, Iraq, and Egypt collectively host approximately 5.5 million Syrian refugees and have partnered up with the UNHCR and local and international agencies to propose initiatives to offer refugee children quality education (UNHCR, 2023). Those include policy adjustments (Kuru et al., 2023), tuition and fee waivers (Maadad & Matthews, 2018), double shifts, in which children from the host country attend school in the morning and refugee children in the afternoon (Mrayan & Saleh, 2020), and government plans, such as the Reaching All Children with Education (RACE) strategy offered by the Lebanese government, which aims to combine investments on school facilities and educational quality, with a focus on training future educators, tracking student progress, and implementing school-based administration (Watkins & Zyck, 2014), dropout educational centers, intended to offer learning opportunities focused on a "catch-up system" for students to make up for years missed out of school (Hattar-Pollara, 2019), literacy centers (Mrayan & Saleh, 2020), “homework cafes” with teachers offering assistance in completing their school work (UNHCR, 2023), and facilities to address other issues, such as assisting minors who are in legal trouble (UNHCR, 2014).

In the 2023-2024 academic year, the DAFI (Albert Einstein German Academic Refugee Initiative) scholarship program has provided 84 eligible refugee and returnee students with the opportunity to get an undergraduate degree in their host country, and 9,303 children attended accelerated education programs to prepare for mid-term and final exams (UNHCR, 2023). Additionally, in their free time, boys are offered the opportunity to engage in extracurricular activities adapted to trauma reduction methodologies, including the Lebanese Scouts, games, storytelling, and music programs with the Swedish Clowns without Borders

(UNHCR, 2016), which, along with protective services like mental health and psychosocial counseling, may prevent violence against children by addressing the various factors that contribute to protection violations holistically (UNHCR, 2022).

Funding

Finance is considered the greatest challenge for refugees to access education and must be addressed in a particular way when discussing the Syrian crisis (UNHCR, 2022). Funding is needed to raise the standard of instruction, address challenges that may limit access to education, and, consequently, reduce school dropouts (UNHCR, 2023). Without it, host countries, and organizations such as the UNHCR may face hardships in keeping up with high operational costs, including infrastructure, and staff salaries (Charles & Denman, 2013), which can make them prioritize domestic students by restricting the registration of Syrians (Maadad & Matthews, 2018). The crisis is worsened by the lack of external aid donors. Currently, led by the European Union, Germany, and the United States (UNHCR, 2022), only a few donors have made significant contributions to UNHCR programs (Watkins & Zyck, 2014) and other educational initiatives that may allow, for instance, tutoring in Arabic and French, which are crucial for assisting refugee children in integrating into public schools (UNHCR, 2023), transportation from and to school, and learning materials (UNHCR, 2022).

UNHCR received $110 million less in financing in 2023 compared to 2022 to operate in the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) region. The worst financial shortages were in Jordan, Lebanon, and Syria, putting refugee populations at risk and making it more difficult to receive services, such as shelter, health, winterization, and other important support needed to survive (UNHCR, 2023).

Despite other significant past contributions, such as USAID's $45 million donation for education programs in Lebanon from 2014 to 2018, and United Kingdom's No Lost Generation strategy with a commitment of £55 million over three years through NGOs such as the Norwegian Refugee Council and the International Rescue Committee, there is still a strong uncertainty regarding those supports. International organizations and governments out of host countries are concerned regarding public financial

management that prioritize, for example, fighting terrorist groups, and may not be convinced by an "educational crisis", which is not as compelling as images of bombing attacks (Watkins & Zyck, 2014).

Rethinking resource allocation and educational policies

Organizations often prioritize the number of Syrian students receiving educational services and the duration of their time in school over the quality of these services (Alodat & Almomani, 2019). However, quality in education is more critical than quantity for fostering both social and individual development (Glewwe et al., 2014). As a result, evidence indicates that Syrian refugee children continue to lack sufficient training in hard skills that would prepare them for higher education and careers, such as participation in vocational training programs and job placements.

As guaranteed by Article 28 of the Convention on the Rights of the Child, education is a universal fundamental right, and, even though the increasing influx of Syrian refugees and limited resources may challenge the UNHCR and local agencies, organizations are pushed to rethink resource allocation in their educational policies and projects in a way that does not limit how many refugee children will have access to it. Those should include expanding low-cost and effective interventions that focus mainly on the quality of education offered and address additional challenges in accessing quality education, including health, transportation, child labor, and early marriage.

In *Poor Economics*, Banerjee and Duflo (2012) provide examples of how inexpensive solutions can effectively address some of these issues. For instance, the authors note that bleach can be used to fully purify water for a family of six at a cost of approximately $0.18, which is about 97% less than the current monthly expenditure on drinkable water for Syrian families in non-permanent shelters (UNHCR, 2022). Such a solution could, therefore, help around 20,000 refugee households who still do not have access to potable water in Lebanon, improving their living conditions and reducing the incidence of diseases such as diarrhea. This improvement is crucial for ensuring better health, enabling children to attend school, and, in the long term, helping break poverty traps (UNHCR, 2022; VASyR, 2022).

Future of Refugee Children

After acquiring valuable skills through a long-term process, Syrian refugee children could become agents of change, impacting future generations and contributing to societal rebuilding and the promotion of stability after the crisis (Zetter, 2020). During their time in refuge, they are introduced to a new curriculum that, once successfully adapted, offers opportunities to engage with foreign languages and international perspectives.

Education boosts productivity and drives scientific development (Jiménez Bandala & Andrade, 2017). Economic models have shown that, in the long run, economic growth leads to technological progress, which is a direct outcome of education. Furthermore, education can reduce fertility rates and enhance the productivity of private investments (Glewwe et al., 2014). As a result, by acquiring skills and securing proper employment, refugees are better equipped to make informed and responsible decisions. In the future, they could even become key actors in addressing the gaps in aid and funding, offering "external support" that reduces household risks and helps escape poverty traps (UNESCO, 2017).

Conclusion

The Syrian crisis has caused families to lose their homes, stability, and, consequently, access to consistent and quality education for the last decade. Under such pressing needs, international organizations, host countries, and local agents have tried to bring educational reforms that could somehow support the refugee children population. These range from policy adjustments to changes in the school environment, such as the double shift (Mrayan & Saleh, 2020). However, their ability to provide quality education is challenged by the large influx of refugees and the inadequate funding and resource allocation that often only focuses on the quantity and not the quality of education offered (Alodat & Almomani, 2019) and mostly ignores other barriers to access educational projects and facilities. Therefore, while dealing with limited resources, agents should base themselves on past successful humanitarian interventions and focus on cost-efficient solutions that also address other factors that pose significant challenges, such as access to healthcare, and basic living conditions. This would shift families' attention and enable refugee children to access proper education, which can, in the long term, allow them to become agents of change, fight systemic poverty, and advance social and economic development among the Syrian refugee population.

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